

CONFIDENT

TEXT: 2 Timothy 1:11-12 *“I was appointed a preacher, an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles. ¹² For this reason I also suffer these things; nevertheless I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed and am persuaded that He is able to keep what I have committed to Him until that Day.”*

INTRO: Over the next four Sunday's we are going to be talking about being confident. This world has a way of shaking our confidence at many levels. Dictionard.com defines confidence as *“Having strong belief or full assurance.”*

Most people begin their adult life filled with anticipation and confidence. Somewhere along the line dreams and reality seem to collide as the battering ram of life crashes through hopefulness and oftentimes what's left isn't really worth talking about.

Confidence is a big deal. Obtaining confidence is not easy and retaining and maintaining it is even more difficult. The only thing that can guarantee confidence over the entire journey of life is faith in God. (R.W. Shambach – “*You don’t have any trouble. All you need is faith in God.*”)

Hebrews 10:32-36 (NKJV) “*Recall the former days in which, after you were illuminated, you endured a great struggle with sufferings:*

³³ Partly while you were made a spectacle both by reproaches and tribulations, and partly while you became companions of those who were so treated; ³⁴ for you had compassion on me in my chains, and joyfully accepted the plundering of your goods, knowing that you have a better and an enduring possession for yourselves in heaven. ³⁵ Therefore do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward. ³⁶ For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise.”

The Hebrew Christians who stood with Paul for the Gospel's sake knew firsthand the damage the wrecking ball of life could deliver. Hebrews 10:32-33 (NKJV) ***"After you were illuminated, you endured a great struggle with sufferings: ³³ Partly while you were made a spectacle both by reproaches and tribulations, and partly while you became companions of those who were so treated."*** These people were being given the old one two punch. They were being considered evildoers because of their faith, and they were considered lawbreakers because of those they were associating with. (You can tell a lot about a person by who they hang out with) (Preacher in Arkansas who wanted to break fellowship because someone told him he was *"Going to be guilty by association."*)

Look a little closer at the word ***"Confidence"*** in Hebrews 10:35 Parrhsia (Par-rhay-see-ah) and means: *"To be outspoken, frank or blunt."*

Dictionard.com defines confidence as “*Having strong belief or full assurance.*” So, as we consider confidence over the next few weeks, we are speaking of being so sure about a matter that we don’t mind speaking frankly about it with great assurance.

Confidence is a big deal.

Over the next four weeks we are going to talk about being:

- Confident about our eternity...
- Confident that He hears us when we pray...
- Confident that He is working all things for our good...
- Confident that He is coming again...

CONFIDENT IN OUR ETERNITY

Many people have trouble believing that one can be confident about their salvation. They say things like:

- I hope I’m saved... (When He saved me He gave me a know so salvation – Gentleman at

Scottsville Arkansas who told me after my sermon that we couldn't possibly know for sure whether we were saved or not, until we die)

- Time will tell... (Time won't tell anything – The thing that is going to tell is whether our names are written down in Heaven)
- I'm doing everything I can to make it... (One cannot get to Heaven by doing good deeds)

Please let me make one thing very clear. There is a real eternity out there! All of us have a date with eternity! Hebrews 9:27 (NKJV) ***“It is appointed for men to die once, but after this the judgment.”***

Go to the cemetery:

- There are small graves and large graves...
- There are old graves and new graves...
- The residents die young and old...

- The residents die rich and poor... (Someone asked how much money Howard Hughes left behind – “*All of it.*”)
- The residents die educated and uneducated...

There is no escaping it, we are all creatures of eternity. Each of us is going to spend eternity somewhere:

- Heaven...
- Hell...

Sorry to disappoint you but there is no in between stop over, rest area kind of place.

I don't think any of us intend to go to hell so how can we be confident that our eternity has been secured? How can we be assured our ticket has been punched? How can we be sure we are going to a better place when we leave this, not so perfect place?

Listen to the dialogue between Jesus and Nicodemus. John 3:1-8 (NKJV) *“There was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews. ² This man came to Jesus by night and said to Him, ‘Rabbi, we know that You are a teacher come from God; for no one can do these signs that You do unless God is with him.’ ³ Jesus answered and said to him, ‘Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.’ ⁴ Nicodemus said to Him, ‘How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter a second time into his mother’s womb and be born?’ ⁵ Jesus answered, ‘Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. ⁶ That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. ⁷ Do not marvel that I said to you, ‘You must be born again.’”*

In this passage of Scripture, Nicodemus makes an observation that Jesus couldn't do the things

he was doing apart from being a man sent from God. This vote of confidence from Nicodemus (Who was a ruler of the Jews) must have seemed pretty nice to Jesus.

Jesus decided not to allow the conversation to get bogged down with all the niceties and mutual admiration comments. He decided to ratchet up the conversation a little and when He did, Nicodemus was totally unprepared for what was to come next. Jesus said, ***“Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.”*** Please know, one cannot be saved by:

- Church membership...
- Leveraging the relationship of a pastor...
- Generous giving and doing good deeds...

There is only one way to salvation and that is through Jesus Christ and the sacrifice He offered through the cross.

Nicodemus wondered out loud whether he as a grown man could enter the second time into his mother's womb and be born again? We must admit, we do use some interesting phrases around church:

- Washed in the blood... (Couldn't that be a little bothersome?)
- Covered by the blood... (Isn't that a little risky? Sounds like a spiritual Waffle House – Scattered, smothered and covered)
- The lamb has been slain... (Shouldn't someone call the animal rights people?)
- On fire for God... (Shouldn't we call the fire department?)
- I'm coming out... (I didn't think we believed in a gay lifestyle)
- I'm going through... (Going through what?)
- Hang on brother... (To what?)
- Turn loose... (Won't I fall?)

The response of Jesus to Nicodemus' inquiry of the prospects of actually being able to be born

again tells the whole story of being confident about our eternal destiny. ***“Jesus answered, ‘Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. ⁶ That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.’”***

When He speaks of the water, He is speaking of the natural birth. When a baby is born, the mothers water breaks as the baby comes down the birth canal to discover America. This is the first birth.

One must be born a natural birth before a spiritual birth is possible. Once one has had a natural birth he/she is now trapped in a place of decision about a spiritual birth. This process is called being born again.

One cannot inherit eternal life based on making some good decisions or being a doer of good deeds. Everything has to change, and the only

way that is going to happen is by being born again!

2 Corinthians 5:15-21 (NKJV) *“For the love of Christ compels us, because we judge thus: that if One died for all, then all died; ¹⁵ and He died for all, that those who live should live no longer for themselves, but for Him who died for them and rose again. ¹⁶ Therefore, from now on, we regard no one according to the flesh. Even though we have known Christ according to the flesh, yet now we know Him thus no longer. ¹⁷ Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new. ¹⁸ Now all things are of God, who has reconciled us to Himself through Jesus Christ, and has given us the ministry of reconciliation, ¹⁹ that is, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not imputing their trespasses to them, and has committed to us the word of reconciliation. ²⁰ Now then, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were*

pleading through us: we implore you on Christ's behalf, be reconciled to God. ²¹ For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him."

Galatians 2:20 (KJV) *"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me."*

CONCLUSION:

There is no question, one can be confident about their eternity! On the cross Jesus made it possible for those of us who have been born once, to be born again.

The cross is the birth canal of every single person who has ever punched their ticket to Heaven. There is no other path that leads to the everlasting Kingdom of Heaven.

Those who are born once die twice – They die a natural death and a spiritual death. Those who have been born twice (again) die only once – The natural death. In this scenario, there is no spiritual death.

If you haven't been born again, you will not find a better time than right now. 2 Corinthians 6:1-2 (NKJV) *“We then, as workers together with Him also plead with you not to receive the grace of God in vain. ² For He says: “In an acceptable time I have heard you, And in the day of salvation I have helped you.” Behold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation.”*

CONFIDENT HE HEARS US WHEN WE PRAY

**CONFIDENT HE IS WORKING ALL
THINGS FOR OUR GOOD**

**CONFIDENT THAT HE IS COMING
AGAIN**